

COUTURE CLASH

Fall-outs and fee hikes. Two months before the spring-summer show, FDCI faces yet another fashion fracas.

FALLING APART: Model at the Wills Lifestyle Fashion Week last year

■ By Kimi Dangor

The Fashion Design Council of India (FDCI) could well be re-named Fashion Disaster Council of India if its penchant for running into trouble is anything to go by. First came the news of its divorce from title sponsor Lakme and event organiser IMG. Now one year, two seasons and a few associate sponsors later, FDCI has parted ways with event management company Percept D'Mark (PDM).

From haute couture to hot water, rumblings of trouble in Wills Lifestyle India Fashion Week's (WIIW) prêt paradise started last season when cracks were reported in the FDCI-PDM combine. But FDCI Director-General Rathi Vinay Jha, PDM CEO Preeta Singh and the rest of the cheerleading brigade put up a brave front and denied the rumours. Singh had valiantly declared then, "We have a three-year contract with FDCI and we want to fulfil it." But nearly 18 months into the agreement, the marriage has ended and Singh is no longer with PDM.

After moving bag, baggage and designer bounty to The Ashok Hotel last season, the WIIW is in for another change in address, with the latest roosting place being Pragati Maidan in Delhi, allegedly garnered at heavily discounted prices. Apart from the venue veering, FDCI's cash register is all set to ring with an announced hike in

show fees. Participation fee has been increased from Rs 2 lakh to Rs 2.5 lakh for a solo show (with one exhibition stall as part of the deal). An extra stall will cost another Rs 25,000.

Is the FDCI milking designers for all it can, as the competition is surreptitiously

suggesting? No, says Jha. "We are working within the constraints imposed by the lack of infrastructure. Designers have to pay more for the facilities and exposure we are providing. It's high time that the fee was increased. Internationally, at fashion weeks, designers have to bear 100 per cent cost. Even after the hike, our de-

The FDCI's cash registers are all set to ring with a Rs 50,000 hike in fee for a solo show.

ISHAN TANKHA